individuals in the betterment of society, he donated Rs 1 lakh for the erection of a memorial in India to General Booth, the founder of the Salvation Army.

He believed in going to the root of the causes of poverty in India and making sustainable changes. Towards this goal, he instituted ‘a chair for investigation and research into causes of destitution and poverty’ at the London School of Economics. He began with a ‘generous donation of £ 1,400 per year [equivalent to £132,318 in 2023 or Rs 13,422,881] for three years to the University of London to fund research into poverty and inequality’. The chair continues to provide leadership in research in the area.

Sir Ratan also made liberal contributions towards the Servants of the India Society started by Gopal Krishna Gokhale. The movement which began in ‘1905 to unite and train Indians’ was devoted to the upliftment of the ‘underprivileged, rural and tribal people, emergency relief work, the increase of literacy, and other social causes’. He followed the activities of the organization closely and was regularly ‘apprised’ of its activities.

As a nationalist and patriot, Sir Ratan was deeply moved by the struggle led by Mahatma Gandhi against apartheid in South Africa and was a source of great support for it. After giving a second instalment of Rs 25,000 to the struggle in Transvaal in 1910, he wrote a moving letter to Mahatma Gandhi stating that he felt acutely for the need to support the movement in its ‘most unequal struggle’. During the period 1909–13, he had donated Rs 125,000 (approximately equivalent to Rs 7 crore in 2023) towards the struggle.

The support came at such a crucial time for Mahatma Gandhi that he wrote: ‘Parsis are known the world over for their generous gifts. Mr Tata has been true to that spirit of generosity.’

Sir Ratan extended his support whenever he determined that it would help the cause of the nation. Thus, he part-funded India’s first ‘archaeological excavation at Pataliputra’ that resulted in the famous discovery of the throne room of Emperor Ashoka. Sir Ratan’s unwavering determination to contribute to societal causes was evident in the endowments he made and was most emblematic in his will of 1913 whereby he pledged virtually all his wealth for the society. He also left instructions to its trustees on how the funds were to be ‘utilised’.

‘The causes to be aided by the funds were to be public in general.’ They related to ‘education, learning and industry in all their branches’. ‘These